

NILOTPAL BARUAH

MISSION REHAB
Amrit Baishya with his wife Bornali Baishya at Shrishti in Guwahati

ious rehab centres to make ends meet. Alongside, he attended motivational meetings, often held among addicts who were trying to recover, at the Don Bosco church. It was in one of those meetings that Amrit met Bornali, a graduate in economics and a former addict herself, and the two fell in love.

Meanwhile, Amrit's parents, impressed with his determination to put his life on track, reached out to him. Amrit, though, chose to spend more time at the rehab centres than at home, and devoted himself to rescuing others who had fallen in the dark abyss that he had once found himself in. He and Bornali tied the knot in January 2020, but they wanted to make their togetherness a meaningful one. The two took a loan of Rs 3 lakh from their parents and, in August 2020, set up Shristi Wellness Home, a rehab centre in the Hengrabari area of Guwahati. In the past two years, the couple, now blessed with a 14-month-old daughter, has helped more than 70 addicts recover from various stages of addiction and return to normal life. Currently, 60 men and 19 women are getting treated at Shristi Wellness Home.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Our centre and many others became more relevant as the Assam Police's war on drugs left them unavailable for addicts and many started having severe withdrawal symptoms. With no opportunity to return to drugs, they responded well to treatment"

— AMRIT BAISHYA, Founder, Shrishti Wellness Home

Their collective mission to help the maximum number of drug addicts received a big boost when the Assam Police launched a war against drugs after Himanta Biswa Sarma took charge as chief minister in May 2021. "Our centre and many others became more relevant as suddenly many addicts started having severe withdrawal symptoms because drugs were not available. With no opportunity to return to drugs, they responded well to the treatment," says Amrit.

The Assam police appreciate Amrit and Bornali's efforts, particularly how their spreading of awareness has brought down the demand for drugs and reform of addicts. Indeed, besides running the rehab centres, the duo, along with several other reformed addicts, also conduct regular awareness programmes, particularly in areas known to be hubs of drug peddling. "The story of this couple is inspiring for everyone," says Bhaskar Jyoti Mahanta, Director General of Assam Police.

"They have helped us create a positive environment. We can arrest drug peddlers, but people like Amrit and Bornali help many vulnerable youngsters stay away from the dangerous path to self-destruction." No one can know it better than them. They have been there. ■